10,000 BLACK INTERNS · CLASS OF 2027 · GUIDE

What makes it different

How Investment Management, Sales and Public Relations stand apart from the industries next to them, what a genuinely compelling "why this one?" sounds like, and what you need to show to make it believable.

Investment Management

vs investment banking, trading, wealth, private equity, insurance, consulting

Sales

vs marketing, customer success, consulting, recruitment, business development

Public Relations

vs marketing, advertising, journalism, public affairs, social media, investor relations

Use this with the Industry Guide (what each industry is) and the Finding Your Why workbook (your personal reasons). This guide covers the middle step: **why this industry rather than its nearest alternative**. Comparisons are general. Individual firms and roles vary. Prepared October 2026.

NAVIGATION

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START

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The "why this, not that?" test

Every reader has a silent question: **"Could this person have written the same answer for a different industry?"** If your reason for Investment Management works just as well for investment banking, it isn't a reason for Investment Management. It's a reason for "finance".

The distinctiveness ladder

↑ Aim for Levels 3–4 in every answer

Level 4 · The role + you	"...and I want to be the person who explains that process to clients, as I saw at [firm]."
Level 3 · The industry	"I'm drawn to managing savings over decades, where the client relationship lasts years."
Level 2 · The sector	"I'm interested in finance and the markets."
Level 1 · Any job	"I want a challenging, fast-paced role where I can develop my skills."

The five ingredients of a compelling reason

1 · Distinctive. A feature that is true of *this* industry, or truer here than anywhere else (Sections 1–3 list these).

2 · Personal. It connects to something you value or experienced (Finding Your Why workbook).

3 · Evidenced. Something you did shows the interest is real, not theoretical.

4 · Informed. It uses the industry's real mechanics correctly (how it makes money, who the client is).

5 · Forward-looking. It points to what you'll contribute and become, not just what you like.

The quick check: replace the industry name in your sentence with its nearest neighbour. If the sentence still works, it isn't distinctive. Rewrite it.

EXPERT INSIGHT

Why this matters more for 10,000 Black Interns: you're matched to a firm at random within the workstream. That firm's reader knows you also chose two other workstreams, and may wonder whether you really want *their* industry. A clearly distinctive reason in each answer removes that doubt.

1

Investment Management

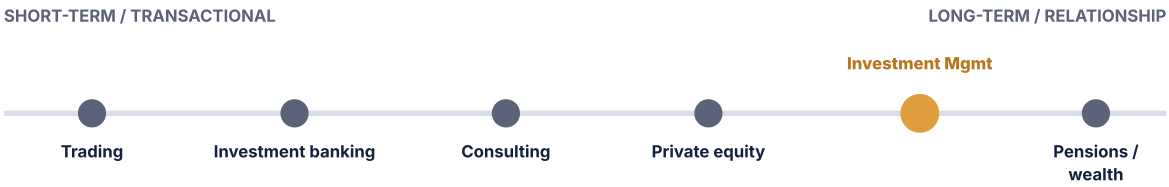
It sits next to several "finance" industries that candidates often blur together. Knowing exactly how it differs is the fastest way to sound like an insider.

1. IM vs its neighbours
2. Seven things only (or mostly) true of IM
3. Weak vs compelling reasons, and "why not X?"

1A · IM vs its neighbours

Industry	What it does	Client	How it makes money	Time horizon	How IM is different
Investment Management	Invests pooled savings in shares, bonds and other assets for clients	Pension funds, insurers, wealth managers, individuals	**Recurring** % fee on assets managed	**Years to decades**	—
Investment banking (IB)	Advises companies on mergers and raising money	Companies, governments	One-off fees when deals complete	Weeks to months, deal by deal	IB is **transactional** and advises. IM is **ongoing** and owns the investment decision and its outcome.
Markets / sales & trading	Buys and sells securities for clients; makes markets	Asset managers, hedge funds (IM firms are *their* clients)	Trading spreads, commissions	Seconds to days	S&T is the **sell-side** serving IM. IM is the **buy-side**, the client with the money.
Wealth management	Holistic financial advice and portfolios for individuals and families	Wealthy individuals	% fee on assets, plus advice fees	Long term	Wealth is **one person's whole financial life**. IM builds the investment strategies and funds, often *used by* wealth managers.
Private equity (PE)	Buys and runs whole private companies, then sells them	Pension funds, SWFs, endowments (as LPs)	Management fee + share of profits (carry)	5–10 years per fund	PE is a **narrow, concentrated** part of the wider IM world. IM spans every asset class and millions of savers.
Insurance	Pools risk; pays claims; provides annuities	Individuals and businesses	Premiums minus claims, plus investment returns	Long term	Insurers **take on** risk. Asset managers **manage** other people's risk and money (and insurers are often IM clients).
Consulting	Advises organisations on strategy and problems	Companies, public sector	Project fees / day rates	Weeks to months	Consultants **recommend**. Asset managers **decide and are accountable** for results, daily and publicly.
Retail / commercial banking	Deposits, loans, payments	Individuals, businesses	Interest margin, fees	Ongoing	Banks **lend** deposits. IM **invests** savings in markets on clients' behalf, and clients own the assets.

Where IM sits



Simplified. IM's defining trait is long-horizon, recurring relationships built on trust and measured performance.

1B · Seven things only (or mostly) true of IM

These are your raw material for a distinctive answer. Pick the one or two that genuinely resonate, and back them with your own experience.

1 · You're the buy-side: the decision-maker

Banks advise and execute; asset managers **decide** where trillions go and live with the result. The client side represents that decision-making to the people whose money it is. **Distinctive vs:** IB, consulting, S&T.

2 · Relationships measured in years, not deals

Revenue is a recurring fee for every year a client stays, so the business is built on **retention and trust**, not one-off wins. A mandate can last a decade or more. **Distinctive vs:** IB, trading, consulting.

3 · The end client is ordinary savers

Behind every pension scheme are thousands of teachers, nurses and shop workers. IM's **fiduciary duty** links daily work to whether real people retire comfortably. **Distinctive vs:** IB, PE, trading (where clients are institutions or companies).

4 · Results are visible and measured constantly

Funds are priced daily and compared with benchmarks and peers. There's nowhere to hide, which demands honesty and humility when explaining performance. **Distinctive vs:** consulting and advisory, where outcomes are harder to measure.

5 · Breadth: the whole economy is your subject

A global portfolio touches every industry, country and economic trend. Few careers make you think about technology, energy, healthcare and interest rates in the same week. **Distinctive vs:** sector-specific industries.

6 · Influence through ownership (stewardship)

As shareholders, asset managers vote and engage with company boards on strategy, pay and climate. That is long-term influence over how companies behave. **Distinctive vs:** banking, consulting, insurance.

7 · Compounding: patience is the strategy

The industry rewards long-term thinking, both in investments (compounding returns) and in relationships (compounding trust). In a short-term world that's genuinely unusual. **Distinctive vs:** trading, deal-driven roles.

Bonus · Translating complexity into confidence

Client-facing IM roles exist to turn complex processes (attribution, risk, private markets) into clear explanations for trustees and advisers, a skill increasingly central under Consumer Duty. **Distinctive vs:** back-office or purely technical finance roles.

EXPERT INSIGHT

The strongest IM reasons combine #2 and #3: a business built on *long-term trust* with clients whose money ultimately belongs to *ordinary people*. That combination doesn't exist in IB, trading or consulting, and it's the natural justification for wanting the client-facing side.

1C · Weak vs compelling reasons, and "why not X?"

Weak reason	Why it's weak	Compelling version
"I'm interested in the stock market."	Equally true of trading, equity research or personal investing	"I'm interested in how long-term investment decisions are explained to and trusted by the people whose savings they are."
"Finance is fast-paced and challenging."	Also IB, S&T, consulting	"I want to be measured on long-term outcomes. Every fund is judged daily against its benchmark, so honesty with clients is essential."
"It's well paid and prestigious."	Never say this, and it's true of IB too	(Don't use pay. Use purpose, responsibility or relationships.)
"I want to help people with their money."	Sounds like financial advice or wealth	"I want to help institutions like pension schemes invest well, because their decisions shape how thousands of members retire."
"I enjoyed my internship."	A feeling, not a reason	"My internship showed me that revenue depends on assets clients keep, so the trust built in every client meeting matters as much as returns."

Ready answers to "why not...?"

...investment banking?
"Banking is transactional: each deal ends. I'm drawn to IM because relationships and results build over years, and the firm is accountable for outcomes that affect ordinary savers."

...sales & trading?
"Trading is short-term and serves the buy-side. I want to be on the buy-side, where decisions are made with a long horizon and explained directly to the end client."

...wealth management?
"Wealth is about one individual's whole financial life. I'm more interested in how investment strategies are built and distributed at scale, to pensions and to the wealth managers themselves."

...the investment team (PM / analyst)?
"I'm fascinated by investing, but what I enjoyed most was the client side: understanding what a client needs and explaining the process so they trust it. I want to understand portfolios deeply in order to do that well."

...private equity?
"PE is concentrated in a few companies. I like IM's breadth across asset classes, and that its clients reach millions of savers."

...consulting?
"Consultants recommend; asset managers decide and are measured every day. I want that accountability."

What's needed to make the IM reason believable: (1) your AM experience described as a specific task and lesson; (2) one correct mechanic (fees on AUM, retention, institutional vs wholesale); (3) one live trend (Guide B13); (4) a signal of commitment, e.g. following markets in the FT or Citywire, an investment society, or starting the IMC.

2

Sales

Sales is often confused with marketing, customer service or "being good with people". What actually makes it different is that it is the **most directly measurable link between a person and revenue** in any business.

1. Sales vs its neighbours, and what makes it unique
2. Weak vs compelling reasons, and "why not X?"

2A · Sales vs its neighbours, and what makes it unique

Function	What it does	Measured by	How Sales is different
Sales	Converts specific prospects into customers through one-to-one conversations; grows accounts	Revenue closed vs quota, pipeline, retention	—
Marketing	Creates awareness and demand across many people at once	Leads, brand awareness, campaign ROI	Marketing speaks to **many**; sales persuades **one decision-maker at a time** and owns the final yes.
Customer service / success	Supports existing customers; solves problems	Satisfaction, resolution, churn	Service **responds**; sales **initiates** and carries a revenue target (though account management overlaps).
Consulting	Diagnoses problems and recommends solutions	Utilisation, client outcomes	Both diagnose. Sales must also **win commitment** and is paid on the result.
Recruitment	Places candidates in jobs (itself a sales job)	Placements, fees	Recruitment is one specialised kind of sales; the Sales workstream spans every product and industry.
Business development (finance)	Wins clients for banks or asset managers	Mandates, net flows	The same skills in a regulated, long-cycle setting: IM distribution *is* sales.
Retail work	Serves walk-in customers	Store sales	Retail is mostly transactional B2C; professional sales is often **consultative B2B** with long cycles.

Six things only (or mostly) true of Sales

1 · The clearest line to impact
Few roles can point to a number and say "I brought that revenue in". Your contribution is visible.

2 · Instant, honest feedback
Every call, meeting and proposal gives a yes, no or not yet. You learn faster because the market tells you immediately.

3 · Meritocratic
Results are measured and rewarded directly (commission, OTE, promotion), largely independent of background or connections.

4 · You learn the whole business
To sell, you must understand the product, the customer's industry, pricing and competitors. That's why so many leaders started in sales.

5 · Human at its core
Even as AI automates outreach, the decisive moments (trust, negotiation, reading a room) stay deeply human.

6 · Transferable everywhere
Every organisation needs revenue, so sales skills move across industries, including back into finance.

EXPERT INSIGHT

Your most distinctive Sales reason is #1 plus #4: a role where your impact is *measurable*, and where you have to understand a client's business deeply in order to help them. It also links naturally to what you saw in asset management distribution, without making the answer about finance.

2B · Weak vs compelling reasons, and "why not X?"

Weak reason	Why it's weak	Compelling version
"I'm outgoing and love talking to people."	Great sales is mostly listening	"What draws me to sales is the questioning: understanding a client's problem well enough that the solution becomes obvious to them."
"I'm competitive and money-motivated."	Sounds self-serving	"I like being measured on results I can see. Sales is one of the few roles where your contribution shows up directly in the numbers."
"I'm persuasive."	A claim, and a slightly risky one	"I've learned that persuasion lasts only when it's built on genuine value, which is why I'm drawn to account management and repeat business."
"Sales is a fast-paced industry."	Sales is a function, not an industry, and the phrase is generic	"Sales gives faster, more honest feedback than almost any role. Every conversation tells you what's working."
"I want to develop my communication skills."	About you, not them	"I want to learn how experienced salespeople qualify opportunities and handle objections, and contribute by researching prospects and analysing pipeline data."

Ready answers to "why not...?"

...marketing?
"Marketing creates interest across many people. I'm drawn to the one-to-one part: understanding a specific client and earning their commitment."

...consulting?
"I like diagnosing problems, but I want to be accountable for the outcome too, both winning the client's yes and being measured on it."

...customer service?
"I enjoy helping customers, but I want to proactively create value: finding new clients and growing relationships, with a clear target."

...finance, given your AM background?
"Asset management showed me that winning and keeping clients is a skill in itself. I want to build that skill rigorously, wherever it's practised best."

What's needed to make the Sales reason believable: (1) a real example of persuading, selling or fundraising, with a number if possible; (2) evidence of resilience (rejection handled); (3) one correct mechanic (pipeline, conversion, retention, discovery); (4) the AM sales cycle described in sales language; (5) curiosity about customers, not just about selling.

Watch out: the Sales workstream reader could be a software firm, a consumer brand or a media company. If your answer only works for financial services, rewrite the industry-specific parts in general sales language.

3

Public Relations

PR is regularly confused with marketing, social media and journalism. What sets it apart is that it manages **reputation with every stakeholder**, through attention it has to **earn**, including when the news is bad.

1. PR vs its neighbours, and what makes it unique
2. Weak vs compelling reasons, and "why not X?"

3A · PR vs its neighbours, and what makes it unique

Field	What it does	Audience	How PR is different
Public relations	Builds and protects reputation through earned media and stakeholder communication	**All** stakeholders	—
Marketing	Drives demand for products	Customers	Marketing sells products to customers. PR manages trust with **everyone**: investors, staff, regulators, media, communities.
Advertising	Buys space to deliver controlled messages	Customers	Advertising is **paid and controlled**. PR must **earn** coverage by persuading independent gatekeepers, which makes it more credible.
Journalism	Reports news independently	The public	Journalists serve readers. PR serves an organisation, so it needs a journalist's news sense **plus** strategic advocacy.
Public affairs	Influences policy and regulation	Politicians, officials	A specialist branch of PR. PR overall covers the media, the public and other stakeholders too.
Social media management	Runs a brand's social channels	Followers	Social is one channel. PR is the strategy across all channels, including crisis and corporate reputation.
Investor relations	Communicates with shareholders and analysts	Investors	IR is a focused, regulated cousin. Financial PR works alongside IR on the wider media.

Six things only (or mostly) true of PR

1 · It handles the bad news
Marketing goes quiet in a crisis. PR is the function that steps **forward**: results misses, job cuts, failures, scandals.

2 · Earned, not bought
Success depends on persuading independent people (journalists, creators) that something is worth their audience's attention.

3 · Every stakeholder
One week: customers, employees, investors, government, communities. PR thinks about how one message lands with all of them.

4 · Close to leadership
Senior PR people advise CEOs at the most sensitive moments. Reputation is a board-level concern.

5 · Live to the news cycle
The work reacts to the world in real time, so news sense and speed are core skills.

6 · Writing as the core craft
Statements, releases, messages, speeches. Precise words under time pressure are the product.

EXPERT INSIGHT

Your most distinctive PR reason is #1 plus #2: the discipline that earns trust it can't buy, and protects it when things go wrong. Linked to your observation that in finance "trust is the product", it's a reason no marketing-focused candidate can match.

3B · Weak vs compelling reasons, and "why not X?"

Weak reason	Why it's weak	Compelling version
"I love social media."	Social is one channel, and the reason sounds like a consumer habit	"I'm interested in how organisations earn credibility across channels, and how quickly that changes when something goes wrong."
"I'm creative."	PR is also strategy, research and judgement	"I enjoy the problem-solving side of creativity: finding the angle that makes a journalist care about a story."
"I like fashion / celebrities / brands."	Fan interest, not professional interest	"What interests me about consumer brands is how they turn a moment, like a launch or even a mistake, into a story people want to share."
"I'm good with people."	Generic	"I like building relationships based on reliability, which is what makes a journalist trust a PR source."
"I want to shape public opinion."	Can sound manipulative	"I want to help organisations communicate clearly and honestly, because trust built on accuracy lasts longer than spin."

Ready answers to "why not...?"

...marketing?
"Marketing focuses on customers and products. I'm drawn to PR's broader responsibility for reputation with every stakeholder, especially when the news is difficult."

...journalism?
"I share a journalist's curiosity about what makes a story, but I want to apply it strategically, helping organisations communicate well and advising on what to say and when."

...advertising?
"Advertising is powerful but paid for. I'm more interested in earning attention, because third-party credibility is harder to win and worth more."

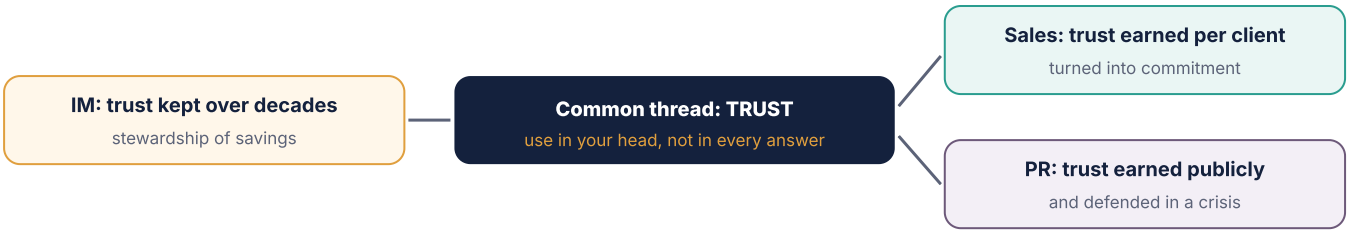
...finance, given your AM background?
"Asset management showed me that reputation directly drives client trust and flows. I want to specialise in how that reputation is built and protected."

What's needed to make the PR reason believable: (1) proof of writing ability (the answer itself, plus an example such as articles, society comms or blogs); (2) a news habit: name what you read and a campaign or crisis you followed; (3) one correct mechanic (earned media, key messages, stakeholders, crisis response); (4) evidence of organisation under pressure; (5) flawless spelling and grammar, because in PR a typo is disqualifying.

4 · All three side by side

	Investment Management	Sales	Public Relations
Core purpose	Grow and protect other people's savings over time	Turn customer needs into revenue	Build and protect reputation and trust
Who you serve	Pension funds, insurers, wealth managers, savers	Business or consumer buyers	Every stakeholder: media, public, investors, staff, government
How money is made	Recurring % of assets managed	Deals × size × retention	Retainers and fees (agency) / protecting value (in-house)
Time horizon	Years to decades	Days to months per deal; years per account	Hours (news, crisis) to years (reputation)
How success is measured	Performance vs benchmark; net flows; retention	Quota attainment; pipeline; churn	Coverage quality, message pick-up, trust, impact
The core skill	Judgement and clear explanation of complex decisions	Discovery: listening and questioning	Writing and news judgement
The emotional reward	Responsibility; long-term relationships; intellectual breadth	Visible impact; winning; instant feedback	Influence; variety; calm in a storm
The hard part	Explaining underperformance; fee pressure	Rejection; targets	Lack of control; unpredictable hours
Distinctive "why"	Long-term trust with clients whose money belongs to ordinary people	Measurable impact, earned by understanding clients deeply	Earning trust you can't buy, and protecting it when things go wrong

The common thread, and the differences that keep answers separate



Same value, three different expressions. That's how you stay consistent without repeating yourself.

5 · What's needed: evidence and skills checklist

A compelling reason is only believable if your CV and answer contain evidence for it. Tick what you can already show and plan how to show the rest.

Requirement	Investment Management	Sales	Public Relations	Where it goes
Genuine, specific motivation	☐ Long-term trust / savers angle	☐ Measurable impact / discovery angle	☐ Earned trust / crisis angle	Answer opening
Relevant experience	☐ AM role: task + lesson	☐ AM sales cycle + a non-finance selling example	☐ AM comms observation + a writing example	CV first + answer proof
Industry knowledge	☐ AUM fees, channels, one trend	☐ Pipeline, retention, one trend	☐ PESO, key messages, one trend	Answer middle
Core skill evidence	☐ Analysis + clear explanation	☐ Listening / persuasion with a result	☐ Writing, plus organisation under pressure	CV bullet + answer
Commitment signal	☐ FT / Citywire habit, society, IMC	☐ Targets hit, fundraising, side hustle	☐ Named publications, PRWeek, campaigns followed	CV interests + answer
Resilience	☐ Handling pressure or deadlines	☐ Handling rejection	☐ Handling last-minute change	Answer proof or interview
Professional standards	☐ Accuracy, discretion	☐ Ethical selling	☐ Flawless writing, honesty	Whole application

The skills each industry values most

Investment Management

- Analytical thinking and numeracy
- Clear written and spoken explanation
- Attention to detail and accuracy
- Long-term relationship building
- Curiosity about markets and the economy
- Integrity and discretion

Sales

- Active listening and questioning
- Resilience and persistence
- Commercial awareness
- Organisation (pipeline, follow-ups)
- Confidence with senior people
- Comfort with targets and data

Public Relations

- Excellent writing and editing
- News sense and curiosity
- Judgement and calm under pressure
- Relationship building (media)
- Research and organisation
- Adaptability to fast change

Gaps are normal. If you can't evidence something yet, don't invent it. Either choose a different angle, or create quick evidence before applying (e.g. start reading PRWeek, write a short LinkedIn post about a market trend, or note the targets you hit in a part-time job).

6 · Putting distinctiveness into 250 words

You don't need to compare industries in your answer. Never write "unlike banking...". Instead, include **one sentence that could only be true of this industry**, and make it carry your personal reason.

Personal value from the workbook + **Distinctive feature** from Sections 1–3 + **Proof** what you did = **Compelling why**

	The "only here" sentence (adapt it, using your own details)
IM	"What sets investment management apart for me is that its relationships are measured in years, not transactions: firms are paid for every year a client trusts them with savings that ultimately belong to ordinary people."
Sales	"Sales appeals to me because it's one of the few roles where your contribution is visible in the numbers, yet the results depend entirely on understanding another person's problem."
PR	"Public relations is the discipline that earns trust it cannot buy, and is the one that steps forward, rather than goes quiet, when things go wrong."

Where it sits in the answer structure



The distinctive sentence goes straight after your hook, so the reader knows within 15 seconds that you understand what makes their industry different.

Final check for each answer

- ☐ Swap in the neighbouring industry's name. Does the answer break? (It should.)
- ☐ Is there one "only here" sentence?
- ☐ Is it tied to a personal value or moment?
- ☐ Is there proof from my own experience?
- ☐ Is there one correct industry mechanic?
- ☐ Could I answer "why not [neighbour]?" in an interview?

Next step: send me your workbook answers (values, money story, moments, AM observations), and say which distinctive feature resonates most for each industry. I'll draft all three answers in your voice, with the "only here" sentence built in.

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